MODULE 27 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

How Snowflake writes questions

Six recurring shapes, and what to do in the room. The last module before the practice exams.

DOMAIN Exam technique WEIGHT - MODULE 27 of 31

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This exam rewards **recognition** over recall. The fact is usually easy. Working out **which** fact is being asked for is the hard part.

The format

- **Around 100 questions in 115 minutes. Multiple choice** and **multiple select**.
- **Scaled score, 750 out of 1000 to pass.** Not a raw percentage, so do not compute a target number of correct answers.
- Delivered through **Pearson VUE**, online-proctored or at a test centre. **$175**, and the credential is valid **two years**.
- **Confirm the current count, time and fee on Snowflake's own page before you book.** These do change.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Scaled scoring means breadth matters. A candidate strong in three domains and blank in two is in more danger than the raw arithmetic suggests.

The timing arithmetic

- 115 minutes for about 100 questions is roughly **69 seconds each**. That is the number to internalise.
- Most questions take **30 seconds**. That is what buys you three or four minutes for the handful that are genuinely hard.
- **The scenario paragraphs are long.** Reading is most of the 69 seconds, which is why recognition beats recall.
- **Flag and move on.** A question you cannot place in 90 seconds will not improve by staring at it.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Practising at 69 seconds a question is the point of the three practice exams that follow. Pace is a skill, and it is trainable.

The six shapes

THE SHAPE	HOW TO RECOGNISE IT
Constraints that stack	Two limits both bind. Fixing one leaves you no better off.
The true statement that answers nothing	An option is factually correct and irrelevant to what was asked.
Defaults nobody chose	Nothing is misconfigured. A documented default is doing its job.
The inverted pair	The right two concepts, with the halves swapped.
The phrase that decides it	One clause in the scenario eliminates three options at once.
Nothing is broken	The described behaviour is correct, and the premise is the error.

ON THE EXAM

Every scenario in this course used at least one of these. Recognising the shape narrows the options before you think about Snowflake at all.

Shape 1: constraints that stack

- Two independent limits both apply, and an option that fixes only one is offered as the answer.
- Example: 30 days of Time Travel on a **transient** table on **Standard**. Transient caps at 1 day; Standard caps at 1 day. Both must change.
- The half-right option is always present, and it is the commonest way to lose these marks.
- **Ask: have I checked every constraint the scenario stated?** Scenarios rarely mention a limit for decoration.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Both Domain drills closed on this shape, in Domain 1 and Domain 2. It is the exam's favourite way to separate near-misses from passes.

Shape 2: the true statement that answers nothing

- An option states something entirely correct about Snowflake that has no bearing on the question asked.
- Example: 'SnowSQL automatic upgrades were disabled from version 1.3.0' offered against a connection timing out. True, and irrelevant.
- These are effective because your instinct is to verify each option's **accuracy** rather than its **relevance**.
- **Ask: does this option answer the question in the final sentence?** Not, is it true.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The habit worth building is re-reading the actual question before choosing. Long scenarios make people answer a question they invented.

Shape 3: nothing is broken

- The behaviour described is **correct**, and the person in the scenario has misdiagnosed it. Sometimes the premise itself is the error.
- Example: a secondary failover group rejecting every write. That is its defining property, not a fault.
- Example: COPY reporting zero rows loaded with no error. Load metadata doing exactly its job.
- The wrong options describe plausible faults, which is what makes them attractive when you expect something to be broken.

> ON THE EXAM
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> This shape is why 'defaults nobody chose' recurred through the course. Most Snowflake surprises are documented behaviour, not bugs.

Shape 4: the phrase that decides it

- One clause in the scenario eliminates most of the options, and the rest of the paragraph is scenery.
- Examples from this course: **'enforced by the database'** forces hybrid tables. **'shown the relevant passages'** forces Cortex Search.
- **'Filtering on different columns each time'** eliminates anything you configure in advance. **'Nobody changed anything'** points at a default.
- Scenarios are written backwards from the answer, so an oddly specific clause is **load-bearing**, not colour.
- **Ask: which single sentence here could not be removed without changing the answer?**

> ON THE EXAM
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> This is the highest-value reading habit in the module. Finding the decisive clause often answers the question before you reason at all.

Shape 5: the inverted pair

- An option names the **right two concepts** with the halves the wrong way round. It exists to catch half-knowledge.
- Example: 'a materialized view for the join, a dynamic table for the single table'. Both correct objects, both misapplied.
- It is **more attractive than a plainly wrong option**, because it uses vocabulary you recognise and looks balanced.
- Defence: name the deciding property, not the pair. **'MV cannot join'** resolves it instantly; 'MV versus dynamic table' does not.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Knowing a distinction exists is not the same as knowing its direction. This shape is built entirely on that gap.

Multiple-select questions

- The prompt tells you how many to pick. **Select two** or **select three** is an instruction, not a hint.
- There is normally **no partial credit**. Two right and one wrong usually scores the same as none.
- Work them as **separate true or false decisions**, one option at a time, rather than looking for a best answer.
- If you are confident about two and torn between two more, the count in the prompt resolves it.
- They take longer than single-answer questions. Budget for that rather than being surprised by it.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The mode change is the point. Single-answer questions reward comparison; multiple-select rewards independent judgement on each option.

Elimination, and when to guess

- **There is no penalty for a wrong answer.** Never leave a question blank, ever.
- Most questions have **two** options you can eliminate quickly. Do that before thinking hard about the remaining two.
- Options containing **always**, **never** or **only** deserve extra scrutiny, though Snowflake does have genuine absolutes.
- If two options say the same thing differently, **neither is usually right**. The answer is one of the other two.
- An option that would be **disproportionate in real life**, like rebuilding an architecture to change a default, is rarely the answer.

> THE ONE RULE
>
> 'Never leave a blank' sounds obvious and people still do it when the clock runs out. Answer everything, then flag for review.

In the room

- **First pass:** answer everything you know in under a minute. Flag anything slower and keep moving.
- **Second pass:** return to the flagged ones with the clock understood and the pressure lower.
- **Change an answer only for a reason you can name.** A specific recalled fact, yes. A vague feeling, no.
- Read the **last sentence** of the scenario first if the paragraph is long. It tells you what to look for while reading.
- Online-proctored: test your setup the day before. Room checks eat into nobody's time but your own.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Reading the question before the scenario is the single most useful habit here. It turns reading into searching.

> 'A team runs a nightly job on a Medium warehouse. Query Profile shows partitions scanned at 3% of total and bytes spilled to remote storage of 180 GB. An engineer proposes adding a clustering key to reduce the partitions scanned.'
>
> You are asked what should be done.

Which shape is this, and what does that tell you?

A Constraints that stack. Both the pruning and the spilling must be fixed together.

B The phrase that decides it. '3% of total' is excellent pruning, so the clustering option is eliminated and spilling is the real issue.

C Nothing is broken. Spilling to remote storage is normal for a nightly job.

D The inverted pair. Clustering and search optimization have been swapped.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which shape is this, and what does that tell you?

A Constraints that stack.

There is only one problem here. The pruning figure is good, so it is not a second constraint but a distractor.

B The phrase that decides it. 3% eliminates clustering.

One number does all the work. Low partitions scanned means pruning is fine, so the engineer's proposal and every clustering option go.

C Nothing is broken.

180 GB spilled to remote storage is a genuine problem. Something really is wrong.

D The inverted pair.

No pair has been swapped. Only one acceleration feature is mentioned.

THE SIGNAL

Notice the engineer's proposal is wrong. A named character suggesting something is often the distractor, not a hint.

> 'An analyst reports that a query which normally returns instantly now takes forty seconds and consumes credits. The underlying table has not changed, the analyst holds the same role, and the query text is identical apart from being reformatted across several lines.'
>
> You are asked why the result was not reused.

Which shape is this?

A Constraints that stack. Both the reformatting and the role must be addressed.

B The inverted pair. The result cache and the warehouse cache have been swapped.

C The true statement that answers nothing. Every option is factually correct.

D The phrase that decides it, plus elimination by exclusion. Two conditions are ruled out explicitly, leaving the third.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which shape is this?

A Constraints that stack.

Only one condition failed. The other two are stated as satisfied, which is the opposite of stacking.

B The inverted pair.

Only one cache is in play. Nothing has been swapped.

C A true statement that answers nothing.

Describes a property of one option, not the structure of the question.

D Exclusion. Two conditions ruled out, leaving the third.

'Table has not changed' and 'same role' are two of the five reuse conditions, stated as satisfied. Reformatting is the third.

THE SIGNAL

Scenarios that tell you what is NOT the problem are doing you a favour. Read those clauses as eliminations, not as background.

> 'A pipeline uses a stream and a task. Inserts reach the target table correctly, but deletions never do. Nobody has changed any configuration since the pipeline was built eight months ago.'
>
> You are asked what is happening.

Which shape is this, and what should you check first?

A Nothing is broken. 'Nobody changed anything' points at a default or a design choice made at build time.

B Constraints that stack. The stream type and the task privileges both need fixing.

C The true statement that answers nothing. Stream staleness is real but irrelevant.

D The phrase that decides it. 'Eight months ago' exceeds every retention window.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which shape is this, and what should you check first?

A Nothing is broken. Check the design choice made at build time.

'Nobody changed anything' plus 'works for inserts' says the pipeline is doing what it was configured to do: an append-only stream.

B Constraints that stack.

One cause explains both observations. There is no second constraint.

C A true statement that answers nothing.

Names a property some option might have. It does not describe the question's structure.

D 'Eight months ago' decides it.

Tempting, and it is the wrong reading. Eight months is how long this has worked correctly, not how long data has been retained.

THE SIGNAL

'Nobody changed anything' is one of the most useful phrases on the paper. It almost always means a default or an original design choice.

What to do with the next three modules

- **Sit each practice exam in one go, timed.** Twenty questions in 23 minutes matches the real pace.
- **Score yourself, then read every explanation**, including the ones you got right. The reasoning is the point, not the tally.
- **Note which shape caught you**, not just which fact. A pattern of misses is more useful than a score.
- Leave a day between them if you can. Three exams in one evening measures stamina rather than knowledge.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Next: three practice exams of twenty questions each, at exam pace, covering all five domains in proportion.